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Breadfruit and empire: moving a living crop

Breadfruit, Artocarpus altilis, is a starchy staple of the Pacific. People there cultivated it long before a British ship asked for cuttings. Many of the kinds grown for food are seedless. You do not ship them as a bag of seed. You ship a living plant: stem, root, and the water and shade those roots need. That is why a warship's cabin was rebuilt as a nursery. The botany is real. It is also the reason the voyage was so easy to ruin.

A seedless fruit has no seed to dry and pocket. Gardeners cut a shoot, keep the cut damp, and wait for roots. At sea the same shoot needs fresh water, air that is not a hold's fug, and space so one mold does not take the whole crate. Those are practical facts. They are also why the first cargo was fragile, and why a mutiny did not merely delay a sack of grain. It ended a greenhouse.

Joseph Banks organized the plan. He did not captain it. The stated use was cheap food for enslaved workers on Caribbean plantations, not a clean gift from one people to another. Scientific care and an oppressive purpose traveled in the same pots. The Banks lesson has the organizer. The Bounty lesson has the mutiny that threw the first cargo away in 1789.

A second try worked. HMS Providence and Assistant, under Bligh again, sailed in 1791 and in 1793 landed breadfruit at St Vincent and Jamaica, first into botanical gardens and then out toward plantations. The trees that grow in the Caribbean now are part of the food of those islands. Genetic studies tie modern cultivars back to Pacific stock moved in that era. A plant can become ordinary in a kitchen and still have a harsh reason for the crossing.

Nothing in that success rewrites the first plan. Ingenuity in keeping a tree alive at sea is not the same thing as a kind motive. The gardeners who received the pots in the Caribbean were doing botany. The people the fruit was meant to feed were not free to refuse the plantation. If you want the ship that failed, read the mutiny. If you want the man who ordered the trees, read Banks. This page is only the crop, and the fact that it was sent as provisions for people who were not free.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Natural History Museum, on Banks: https://www.nhm.ac.uk/discover/joseph-banks-scientist-explorer-botanist.html
- Current Biology (2023), on the genetic history of breadfruit introductions: https://www.cell.com/current-biology/fulltext/S0960-9822(22)01901-7

- Royal Museums Greenwich, William Bligh: https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/william-bligh
- Tropical Agriculture, on breadfruit in the Caribbean: https://journals.sta.uwi.edu/ojs/index.php/ta/article/view/6507

Key facts

- Artocarpus altilis was cultivated in the Pacific long before European voyages. Seedless kinds travel as living plants, not as seed.
- Banks's plan for the Bounty was cheap food for enslaved Caribbean workers, not a purely humanitarian gift.
- The Bounty never delivered. Providence and Assistant brought plants to St Vincent and Jamaica in 1793.
- Modern Caribbean trees are tied by genetics and by history to that transfer. The meal does not erase the purpose.